

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

Epiphany 2
The Light of...Noticing & Honoring

11 January 2026



Giotto de Bondone
Adorazione dei Magi, 1304
Fresco Capella degli Scrovegni ~ Padova, Italy

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Please note that our services are live streamed at fccla.org/live.

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Improvisation on THE SERVANT SONG and GATHER US IN

DAS ALTE JAHR VERGANGEN IST (Johann Sebastian Bach) and Improvisation

Prelude on SAINT STEPHEN (Richard Proulx) and Improvisation

Your Father Would Be Proud from *Rogue One* (Michael Giacchino)

Across The Stars (John Williams)

Paraphrases of two Preludes in C (Bull after Bach and maybe Bach)

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome & Words of Gathering

Lance & Brittany Skiles

Good morning and welcome to worship at First Congregational Church of Los Angeles. On this second Sunday of the Epiphany Season, listen to these Words of Gathering as we begin our series on, *The Art of Living*.

The ancient ones saw it this way:

In the beginning, the Holy One allowed the light,
'Let there be light,'
and from Spirit's being,
radiance emerged
that lit creation's path toward its sacred future.

The scientists see it this way:

In the beginning, from the darkness and emptiness
of nothingness,
an unaccountable explosion of radiation
expanded outward in all directions,
which now our measurements can measure.

The first disciples saw it this way:

Jesus, too, allowed the light to brighten
the shadows of death's reign,
announcing a new creation,
brightened by justice for all.

We might look at it this way:
That same light that shone in Jesus shines now
through us,
and whether this becomes real to us – or not –
depends on whether we allow an eternal shining
to light our path
into a future that awaits
our distinctive stamp.

Let there be light.

May it be so.

May it be so for all of us!

Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

Gather Us In

Here in this place new light is streaming,
Shadows of doubt are vanished away.
See in this space our fears and our dreamings,
Brought here to you in the light of this day.
Gather us in, the lost and forsaken;
Gather us in; our spirits in flame.
Call to us now, and we shall awaken;
We shall arise at the sound of our name.

We are the young, our lives are a mystery;
We are the old, who yearn for your face.
We have been sung throughout all of history,
Called to be light to the whole human race.
Gather us in, the rich and the haughty;
Gather us in, the proud and the strong;
Give us a heart so meek and so lowly;
Give us the courage to enter the song.

Here we receive new life in the waters;
Here we receive the bread of new birth;
Here you shall call your sons and your daughters,
Call us anew to be salt for the earth.
Give us to drink the wine of compassion,
Give us to eat the bread that is you;
Nourish us well, and teach us to fashion
Lives that are holy and hearts that are true.

Not just in buildings, small and confining,
Not in some heaven light years away,
here in this place the new light is shining;
Now is God present, and, now is the day.
Gather us in and hold us forever;
Gather us in and make us your own;
Gather us in, all peoples together,
Fire of love in our flesh and our bone.

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Chad Tanaka Pack

Holy One,
with this new day,
we open our eyes
and we pray:

*God, inhabit our seeing.
Live in our looking.
Be our vision and our sight.
Illumine us, that we may perceive you,
know you, welcome you
in all the ways you are light --
in those who came before us,
in the world around us,
and in each of us.*

Help us to carry this light,
this peace, this hope,
into our world.

[adapt/jrichardson]

*From the depths of our common hope, we pray.
Amen and Amen!*

***Introit**

“‘Tis Thou To Whom Honor Is Owing”
Cathedral Choir

FRANZ JOSEPH HAYDN

***The Lord's Prayer**

Brittany Skiles

*Our [God], who art in heaven,
hallowed be thy Name,
thy kingdom come, thy will be done,
on earth as it is in heaven.
Give us this day our daily bread,
and forgive us our debts,
as we forgive our debtors.
And lead us not into temptation,
but deliver us from evil.
For thine is the kingdom,
and the power, and the glory,
forever. Amen.*

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Tanaka Pack

Whichever way we turn, O God, there is your face
in the light of the moon and patterns of stars
in scarred mountain rifts and ancient groves
in mighty seas and creatures of the deep.

Whichever way we turn, O God, there is your face
in the light of eyes we love
in the salt of tears we have tasted
in weathered countenances east and west
in the soft skin glow of the child everywhere.

*Whichever way we turn, O God, there is your face
there is your face
among us.* [jphilipnewell]

This morning, may the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow

Please be seated

Reading from Our Religious Tradition *The Gospel of Matthew, Chapter 2* **Lance & Brittany Skiles**

This is the Witness of the Ancestors.

Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Tanaka Pack

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

O Holy One,
we dwell in the shadows when we are away from you:
ignorant of our true nature, unaware of life's blessings,
disconnected and isolated from the dance of the cosmos
and the blessing that we are.

We dwell in the light when we open to you:
aware that we are made in your image, blessed by the opportunity
of being alive, at one with all that is, enveloped by you,
luminous in all creation, beyond all thought,
yet present in our 'yes' to life.

Today, and every day, may the light of the Christ shine within us,
among us, and from us, O God, wherever shadows reign.

*We pray all of this and so much more –
in the name of the One
who is the Light of the World.
Amen and Amen!*

Meditation Anthem

"The Prayer"
Molly Pease and Lorenzo Zapata, *Soloists*

DAVID FOSTER, CAROL BAYER SAGER,
TONY RENIS, & ALBERTO TESTA

The Eucharist and Blessings

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Tanaka Pack

Words of Invitation and Remembrance

We have lovingly been called to be a people of God.
Having been given this bread and cup as a reminder of God's love,
we now listen for God's presence in silence and in sound –
we listen in the voices of all people,
we listen to the music of creation,
and in this way, we are reconnected to God
through this holy meal.
In this time may we hear the voice
that calls us home to our Creator, Christ, and Spirit.

We remember the stories of Jesus,
the one who did not have a house of their own,
and yet found home whenever they came to the table with their friends.
To help them remember God's great love for them,
Jesus would take the bread, hold it up for all to see,
and say, 'When you eat this, remember the love with which it is given.'

And then, Jesus would take a cup of the fruit of the vine,
pouring it out for all of them to see and saying,
'This cup is poured out for you – remember the love
that you are now called to give.'

Prayer of Blessing

God of fresh bread and newly harvested fruit of the vine,
we sense your presentness among us
in grace-filled moments of sharing,
in carefully created communities of loving solidarity,
in holy times of birthing new life
from the renewing of our minds.

*We delight in the moving of your steadfast Spirit
that calls us to find water for the thirsty,
invites us to prepare meals for all who hunger,
and gives us the gifts to welcome all in our midst.*

May it ever be so.
Amen and Amen.

Sharing of the Bread and the Cup

At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

Invitation to Generosity

Lance Skiles

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory

"Hark I Hear The Harps Eternal"
Cathedral Choir

arr. ALICE PARKER

*Doxology

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

*Offering Prayer

Brittany Skiles

Holy One,
Light of the world,
be present in us this day.

Rooted in your love,
filled with your peace,
illumined by your grace,
may we always be.

Kindle our hearts into quiet strength,
calm our spirits into restoration
that we may give all that we are
and all that we have,
to bring wholeness to your world again.
May it be so.

*May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!*

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Fregin

Words of Blessing

Rev. Fregin

Holiness, in which we live,
feel our tomorrows
stirring in our hearts this day.

Feel the strength of the dream we have yet to live;
feel the courage of the day we have yet to face.
*Feel the peace of the heart we have yet to heal
and the release of the tear we have yet to shed.*

Feel the hope of the promise we have yet to hear
and the warmth of the embrace we have yet to feel.
Feel all that will be.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Choral Response

"Old Hundredth"
Cathedral Choir

RALPH VAUGHAN WILLIAMS

*Hymn for the Journey

Imagining Stars

THE SERVANT SONG

When, at night, the stars shine on us
Light years from our tiny earth,
Songs and psalms provoke the questions
Of our fragile human worth.

These gigantic specks are burning,
Balls of fire, as at play;
Stars in billions share their light and
Thus create a Milky Way.

We still gaze in raw amazement,
Contemplating timeless space;
Numberless, the stars keep stories
Hidden from our human race.

Tiny holes in heaven's flooring
Letting light beyond shine through;
Stars invite us to imagine
What it is we cannot view.

Myst'ry strides across the canvas
Of the picture we might paint;
Sacredness is grandly present;
Let us praise without restraint.
-lyrics by G. Stuart

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence
Short Fugue in C Major (Ascribed to J.S. Bach)

Inside The Music

"Laura asked me if we could sing "The Prayer" at an upcoming service, and I thought today fit well. The song has been persistently popular since Celine Dion and Andrea Bocelli premiered it. I first sang it for a wedding in the 1990s. The connection to honoring and noticing fit well for the new couple whose life would be enriched by their continual renewed awareness of one another connected to their willingness to create space for each other's needs and interests. I like it for us this week for the same reasons. As we enter this new year with so many uncertainties, we can hold close the words "lead us to a place, guide us with your grace, to a place where we'll be safe." As we hear them circle through out midst, we can hear more deeply the chance we have to be these words for each other, just as we seek divine guidance. The sweetness of the harmonies balance the solo moments such that we can hear the

flow of life together with others being shared in song. The Appalachian song “Hark I Hear The Harps Eternal” centers on transition to the afterlife, but from an observer’s perspective. Although it appears to be at the moment of transition, we can easily consider it as any moment we might reflect on the vastness of creation. The hook, “Glory to the Great I Am,” reveals this hidden promise. From this new perspective, the loved ones who call to us from beyond this life are ancestral voices reminding us to live and love. Parker’s infectious setting has her distinctive drive and use of harmonic 5th stacks. She also utilizes complex rhythmic cells layered on each other, not unlike her contemporary Igor Stravinsky. This rhythmic counterpoint illuminates the connection to all things by expanding our minds in the moment. The invitation to awareness of creation beyond our personal mind loops opens the door to deep honoring of the divine. When we find ourselves connected to the vast world around us, our bodies scream out “glory!” as an expression of that honor.” ~ Dr. David Harris

One License: A-741625 | CCLI: 2052172